

We can see the bill. We cannot see the spend.

Cloud is the one large line where spending decisions are made daily, by people who never see the invoice, with no approval step in between.



No owner on the change

Four in five organizations need a day or more to trace an AI spike to its source.



Data arrives after the fact

Billing lands 24–48h late, so every cost alert reports rather than prevents.



Nothing stops a runaway

No quota, no ceiling, no gate. The first hard limit is the invoice.

What this brief asks for

01

A mandatory tagging standard

Enforced at deployment

02

A named owner per application

A person, not a mailing list

03

Guardrails on by default

Quotas and budget thresholds

No new headcount or tooling spend.

WHY NOW

The discipline moved this year — toward us

FinOps Foundation, State of FinOps 2026 (n ≈ 1,500 practitioners worldwide).

78%

of FinOps practices now report
into the CTO/CIO organization

up 18 points since 2023

98%

of practices now manage AI
spend as a core operating cost

SaaS 90% · licensing 64% · data centre
48%

#3

governance ranks above
optimization in 2026 priorities

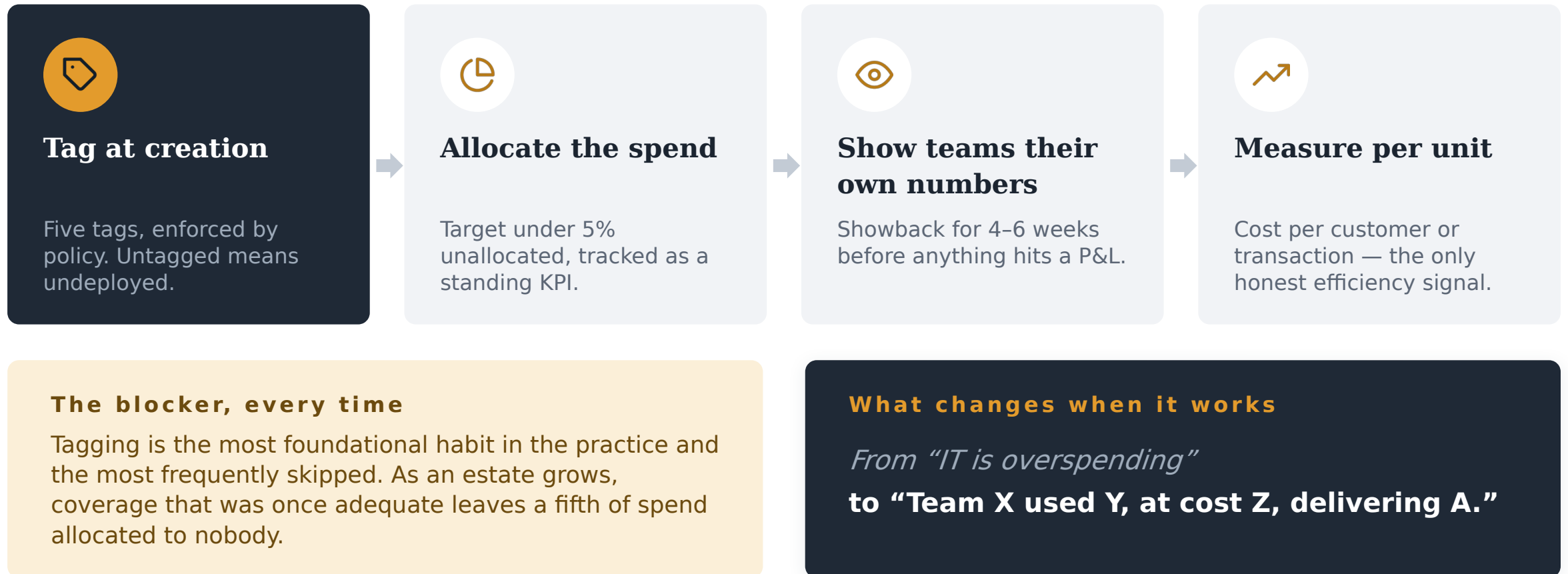
behind only AI cost management and
AI-driven efficiency

What it means for this organization

Cost control has stopped being a finance report and become a technology capability — which puts it on this desk. The industry's own conclusion is that attacking waste after the fact has hit diminishing returns; the returns now come from governance, forecasting and scope.

Allocation is the whole game

Every question worth asking about cloud spend reduces to one prerequisite: can this cost be traced to an owner?



Two moments to control a cost

At design, when changing it is a conversation. After deployment, when changing it is a migration.

BEFORE DEPLOY — SHIFT LEFT

FinOps in the design conversation, where the decisions that commit the money are made.



A seat at design and intake

Understand what the project needs before the architecture is set.



Options priced, target agreed

Two or three costed; a cost target recorded beside the SLOs.



Enforced in the pipeline

Cost diff on the pull request; tagging and budget rules as policy.

AFTER DEPLOY — RUNTIME

Controls that act on spend already running, in the order they take effect.



Quotas and rate limits

Seconds. The only control that stops spend in progress.



Tiered alerts to named owners

Minutes on usage data; never a page on a budget number.



Budget thresholds

Notify, review, gate — measured against the elapsed month.

Pre-deployment costing is the most requested capability in the State of FinOps 2026. It works where FinOps sits with engineers at design rather than auditing them afterwards — and a cost alert still cannot stop a runaway job, because by the time billing moves the money is spent.

THE ASK

Ninety days, three decisions

Weeks 1-4

Standard and baseline

- Publish the tag taxonomy and enforce it on new resources
- Name an owner for every application above a spend floor
- Report allocation coverage as a number, weekly

Weeks 5-8

Shift left, guardrails

- Cost estimate on every infrastructure pull request
- Quotas on the top ten workloads; alerts routed to owners
- Showback: every team sees its own spend, nothing is charged

Weeks 9-12

Review and decide

- Monthly review with finance in the room
- Unit-cost baseline for the two largest products
- Decide whether and when showback becomes chargeback

Decisions needed today

Do we enforce tagging at deployment?

Who owns the taxonomy — and by when?

Are we willing to have a limit that actually blocks?